

To

The Director,
State Council of Educational Research and Training (SCERT), Assam
Kahilipara, Guwahati-781019

Sub: Prayer for the formation of a committee comprising expert linguists to resolve the stalemate over Bishnupriya Manipuri textbooks (FLN) currently under your disposal.

Respected Madam,

We, the office-bearers of the Bishnupriya Manipuri Sahitya Sabha, have the honour to state that we have been actively involved in the preparation (translation) of Bishnupriya Manipuri textbooks (FLN) in line with NEP2020 under your guidance and submitted the same to you. We have followed the grammatical and orthographic plan of Dr. Kali Prasad Sinha, M. A., Ph. D., D. Litt. He was the only internationally acclaimed linguist who extensively worked on this language. His Ph.D. thesis was on the Bishnupriya Manipuri Linguistic study.

According to renowned linguists like Dr. Bani Kanta Kakati, Dr. Suniti Kumar Chattopadhyay, Dr. Kali Prasad Sinha, et al, the auxiliary root used in Assamese, Bengali, Sylheti Bengali, and Bishnupriya Manipuri languages in compound tenses is ‘√আছ্’, derived from the Prakrit root ‘√অচ্ছ. Since ‘√আছ্’ is an incomplete root, the root ‘√থা’ (√থাক্ in Bengali and Assamese), derived from the Sanskrit root, ‘√স্থা’, substitutes it in the future tenses. The examples of root ‘√আছ্’ are given hereunder:

পুরাঘটিত বৰ্তমান কাল	ঘটমান বৰ্তমান কাল
কৰিয়াছু > কৰিছু > কৰেছু (√কৰ্+ইয়া+√আছ্+উ) (বিষ্ণুপ্ৰিয়া মণিপুৰী)	কৰিয়া আছু (√কৰ্+ইয়া+√আছ্+উ) (বিষ্ণুপ্ৰিয়া মণিপুৰী)
কৰছি (√কৰ্+ইয়া+√আছ্+ই) (সিলেটি বাংলা)	কৰতে আছি (√কৰ্+ইতে+√আছ্+ই) (সিলেটি বাংলা)
কৰিয়াছি > কৰেছি (√কৰ্+ইয়া+√আছ্+ই) (বাংলা)	কৰিতে আছি > কৰিতেছি > কৰছি (√কৰ্+ইতে+√আছ্+ই) (বাংলা)
কৰিয়াছোঁ > কৰিছোঁ (√কৰ্+ইয়া+√আছ্+ওঁ) (অসমীয়া)	কৰি আছোঁ (√কৰ্+ইয়া+√আছ্+ ওঁ) (অসমীয়া)

These three sister languages differ morphologically only in the case of their markers (Vibhakti). The other morphemes are the same. The auxiliary roots in these three languages are none other than ‘√আছ্’ and ‘√থা’ (√থাক্ in Bengali and Assamese), in all compound tenses. Therefore, the orthographic plan of Bishnupriya Manipuri, concerning the root ‘√আছ্’, cannot be different from those of Assamese and Bengali. For example, আছে, আছু, আছিল, কৰেছিল, কৰিছিল, কৰিয়াছিল etc.

Regarding the ‘be’ verb, the root is ‘√অ’ in Sylheti Bengali and Bishnupriya Manipuri and the root ‘√হ’ in Assamese and Bengali. The roots ‘√অ’ or ‘√হ’ are complete roots in Bishnupriya Manipuri, Assamese and Bengali. That means in all forms of ‘be’ verbs in

these languages the root ‘√অ’ or ‘√হ’ are there. They need not be substituted by any other root. The derivations are-

ভূ (সংস্কৃত) > হো (প্রাকৃত) > √অ (বিষ্ণুপ্রিয়া মণিপুরী)

ভূ (সংস্কৃত) > হো (প্রাকৃত) > √অ (সিলেটি বাংলা)

ভূ (সংস্কৃত) > হো (প্রাকৃত) > √হ (অসমীয়া)

ভূ (সংস্কৃত) > হো (প্রাকৃত) > √হ (বাংলা)

For example

পুরাণটিত বর্তমান কাল	ভবিষ্যত কাল
অছু / 'ইছু (√অ+ইয়া+√আছ+উ) (বিষ্ণুপ্রিয়া মণিপুরী)	অইতৌ (√অ+ইতৌ) (বিষ্ণুপ্রিয়া মণিপুরী)
অইছি (√অ+ইয়া+√আছ+ই) (সিলেটি বাংলা)	অইমু (√অ+ইমু) (সিলেটি বাংলা)
হইয়াছি (√হ+ইয়া+√আছ+ই) (বাংলা)	হইব (√হ+ইব) (বাংলা)
হইছোঁ (√হ+ইয়া+√আছ+ওঁ) (অসমীয়া)	হ'ম (√হ+ইম) (অসমীয়া)

The grammar and the orthographical plans of these three languages have their natural similarities that make a student, studying in Bishnupriya Manaipuri medium at the foundation stage of NEP-2020, migrate to Assamese or Bengali as the medium of instruction at higher stages without any grammatical and orthographic hassles.

However, it has come to light that another literary organization, Nikhil Bishnupriya Manipuri Sahitya Parishad, Assam, has also involved themselves in the process of the preparation of the Bishnupriya Manipuri textbooks and reportedly submitted the prepared (translated) copies of the same. However, the problem now is that the Nikhil Bishnupriya Manipuri Sahitya Parishad, Assam, follows an erroneous grammar that has no sanctity from any credentialed linguist. Their erroneous grammar litters their every written material with spelling errors, especially in all compound tenses and anything related to the ‘be’ verb, apart from the words derived from Sanskrit roots. To be precise, this lot of writers of the Nikhil Bishnupriya Manipuri Sahitya Parishad, Assam, has spelt disaster for the Bishnupriya Manipuri Language by distorting its ‘be’ verb and the auxiliary verb with the sole intention of creating a deliberate distance from its sister languages like Assamese, Bengali etc. Their erroneous grammar has its reflection on orthography (spelling). Under no circumstances, are we ready to accept our tiny tots to start their foundational education in their mother tongue with erroneous grammar and spelling.

To corroborate this statement, we have right at hand the recently published ‘Bishnupriya Manipuri Byakaran’ by Sri Mathura Sinha, B.A., Normal, and reprinted and published by Shibendra Sinha, General Secretary, Nikhil Bishnupriya Manipuri Sahitya Parishad, Assam, under Bhasha Gaurav Achari, Government of Assam. In this grammar book, Sri Mathura Sinha made a messy concoction of the verb roots ‘√অ’ and ‘√আছ’ as they appear in the Bishnupriya Manipuri language by replacing them with ‘√অস্’ and ‘√আস্’ respectively and creating an unacceptable and unsubstantiated linguistic and grammatical narrative.

According to Sri Mathura Sinha, the Sanskrit root ‘अस्’ is an incomplete root in the Bishnupriya Manipuri language. He says that the Sanskrit root ‘अस्’ is used in the Bishnupriya Manipuri language in simple present, present continuous, simple past, simple future, present injunction, and future injunction with the omission of ‘dental S’. The examples he cites are:

মি অউরি, আমি অয়ার, তা অর, তানু অইতারা etc.

As we know from the works of renowned linguists, like Dr. Banikanta Kakati, Dr. Suniti Kumar Chattopadhyay, Dr. Kali Prasad Sinha, Dr. Smriti Kumar Sinha, et al, the Sanskrit root ‘√अस्’ has no room, at least in Assamese, Bengali, Sylheti Bengali, Oriya, and Bishnupriya Manipuri. It is the root ‘√अ’ in Sylheti Bengali and Bishnupriya Manipuri and the root ‘√ह’ in Assamese and Bengali (both have their derivation from ‘ভূ’), and not ‘अस्’ that Sri Mathura Sinha claims as appearing in all the tenses—simple present and present continuous, simple past, simple future, present injunction, and future injunction—with the omission of ‘dental S’. Since the roots ‘√अ’ and ‘√ह’ (‘ভূ’ in Sanskrit) are complete roots, they appear in present, past, and future tenses without the need for any substitution.

Likewise, he uses the Sanskrit root ‘आस्’ in present perfect and past perfect tenses, and the root ‘था’, derived from Sanskrit ‘स्था’, substitutes it in the rest of the tenses. The examples he cites are –

মি আসু, আমি আসি, তি আসত্ তুমি আস’, তা আসে, তেই আসে, তানু আসি etc.

Here, Sri Mathura Sinha has mistaken these sentences as the present perfect. Since the Bishnupriya Manipuri present perfect tense is a compound tense, it must have an auxiliary verbal root in ‘kriyabibhakti’ (non-finite suffix ইয়া + auxiliary verbal root √आह् + case-gender markers উ, ই, অত্, এ etc.). He mistakenly takes the above sentences bereft of any auxiliary verbal roots as present perfect tenses. The morphemes of these sentences corroborate the fact that these are not perfect tenses. আসু (√আস্+উ), আসে (√আস্+এ) etc. These morphemes are bereft of the auxiliary verbal root ‘√আহ্’. Is any perfect tense possible without an auxiliary root?

The Sanskrit root ‘√आस्’, which Sri Mathura Sinha uses in the Bishnupriya Manipuri compound tenses, is a gross violation of the acceptable rule that says that only stative verbs giving the sense of ‘having and being’ play the role of auxiliaries. The Sanskrit root ‘√आस्’ is a dynamic root. Using this root as an auxiliary in ‘kriyavibhakti’ is a gross misuse of the verbal root.

Our fervent request to your good office is to resolve the academic issue based on the above scientific arguments and accept the textbooks and other study material submitted by the Bishnupriya Manipuri Sahitya Sabha or form a committee of expert linguists and grammarians to ascertain the correct grammar and orthographic plan between the two sets of textbooks submitted to you by the two literary bodies so as to let the Bishnupriya Manipuri students get academically correct textbooks and other study materials.

Insofar as linguistic experts are concerned, there are linguists like

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2. Prof. Amalendu Chakrabarty, former Professor of Bengali, Gauhati University and currently the Vice Chancellor of Rabindranath Tagore University, Hojai, Assam, email: rabindranathtagoreuniversity@gmail.com, (M/W) 9435346359

who you may include in the committee of experts.

From our end, we will send a team comprising

1. Prof. Smriti Kumar Sinha, Vice Chancellor, Pragjyotishpur University, an expert in Computational linguistics, email: smritikumarsinha@gmail.com, (M/W) 9435521564
2. Mrs. Kumkum Sinha, former Director, SCERT, Assam, sinhakumkum09@gmail.com, (M/W) 9435172382
3. Dr. Manas Sinha, Asst. Professor, Sanskrit; and President, Nikhil Bishnupriya Manipuri Sahitya Parishad, email: manassinha.silchar@gmail.com, (M/W) 8638319189
4. Mr. Ramlal Sinha, Executive Editor, The Sentinel, Guwahati, Assam, email: ramlalsinha36@gmail.com, (M/W) 9954965203

as and when you call.

With best regards-

Yours—



Dr. Smriti Kumar Sinha
President
Bishnupriya Manipuri Sahitya Sabha